

Impact: High Difficulty: Easy-Medium Misuse risk: Medium

WHY IT WORKS

'I'll think about it' often reads as a soft no and leaves the other person in limbo — an open loop they have to manage. A bounded deferment with a specific return date converts an open loop into a closed commitment.

WHAT IT IS (AND ISN'T)

- Not a soft no — a bounded deferment carries a real return date, and the answer genuinely arrives.
- Not stalling — the time is for improving the answer, not for hoping the question goes away.
- It is converting 'I'll think about it' from an open loop into a closed commitment with a deadline you keep.

THE PAYOFF

How it lands: When they say 'Friday', the answer arrives Friday — waiting for them never means chasing them.

Principle: Trust attaches to kept deadlines, so a deferred answer delivered on time builds more credibility than a fast one delivered shakily.

What you gain

- Better answers, made with actual thought
- Freedom from commitments made under pressure
- A reputation for reliability that makes people happy to wait
- Negotiating positions chosen, not blurted
- Fewer reversals — decisions made properly rarely need unwinding

Why most people fail at it

- They say 'I'll get back to you' with no date, which reads as a soft no.
- They set the deadline and then miss it, and every future deferral is discounted.
- They defer answers they already know, because the real discomfort is saying them.
- Under pressure they cave and answer anyway, then spend a week regretting the commitment.

CORE FORMULA

Decline to decide now -> Specific return time -> Honour the commitment

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

When you cannot answer properly on the spot, say: 'I cannot give you the right answer now — I can have it for you by [specific time].' Then keep that commitment.

BEST FOR

- Situations where you need time to think before committing
- Pressure to answer before you have adequate information
- Buying time without evasion or dishonesty
- Delaying a decision that needs more input or reflection

METHOD, STEP BY STEP

1. Decline — Decline to decide now

Say plainly that you are not answering on the spot, and why: the answer deserves better. Declining the moment is not declining the question.

Evasive: 'Yeah, maybe, I mean — can we see how it goes?'

Declined: 'I am not going to answer that on the spot — it deserves proper thought.'

2. Time — Name a specific return time

'Later' is an open loop; 'Thursday by noon' is a commitment. Pick a time you are certain you can meet, then say it out loud so it binds you.

Open loop: 'I will let you know soon.'

Bounded: 'You will have my answer by Thursday noon.'

3. Honour — Honour the commitment

Return at the promised time with the answer — or, at worst, with a shorter, explained extension. The kept deadline is what makes your next deferral trusted.

Drift: (Friday passes in silence; they chase you the following week.)

Honoured: 'As promised: I have thought it through, and my answer is yes, with one condition.'

FIELD TIP

The specific time is the whole technique.

'I'll think about it' leaves the other person managing an open loop — chasing you is now their job. Add a concrete return time and the loop closes: they can put it down, because you have visibly picked it up. Then keep the time, or the technique never works again.

Situation: Your manager asks in passing whether you can take on a new project.

Don't: 'Umm — probably? Let me have a think and get back to you at some point.'

Do: 'I want to check my commitments before I answer. I will tell you by ten tomorrow.'

PHRASE BANK

Deferment Phrases · Buying time with a deadline

- "I cannot answer that properly right now. I can get back to you by end of day."
- "That deserves a better answer than I can give you on the spot — give me until tomorrow morning."
- "Let me sit with that — I will come back to you by [time]."
- "I am not in a position to commit to that today. I will have an answer by Friday."
- "I do not want to answer that badly. Can I have until Thursday?"
- "That needs more thought. I will send you my view by noon."
- "I cannot say yes or no right now — I can say yes or no by Wednesday."
- "Give me 24 hours — not to avoid it, but to answer it properly."

Acknowledge Urgency · When they need it faster than you can give

- "I understand you need this quickly — my fastest honest answer is by X."
- "If you need it now, my provisional answer is Y — but I want to confirm that by Z."
- "I can give you my best current read now, with the caveat that it may change."
- "If the decision cannot wait, I would say X provisionally."

Professional Deferrals · Buying time in work settings

- "That is a fair question — I want to check the numbers before I answer it. I will confirm by tomorrow's stand-up."
- "I would rather send you an accurate answer this afternoon than a rough one now."
- "Let me take that away as an action — you will have my answer by Thursday's meeting."
- "I want to consult the team before committing them. I will close this out by Friday."
- "Good challenge. I do not want to improvise the answer — give me until end of day."
- "I will put time in my calendar for this today and reply by five."

Personal Deferrals · Time to process, without distance

- "I care about getting this right more than getting it fast — can we talk tomorrow evening?"
- "I am not avoiding you — I need a night to sit with what you said."
- "That deserves a real answer, not a tired one. Breakfast tomorrow?"
- "I want to respond from a calmer place. I will come to you in the morning."
- "This matters to me, which is exactly why I do not want to answer on the spot."

Deferring Under Pressure · Holding the pause when pushed

- "I understand the pressure to decide now. A rushed answer would cost us more than a day's wait."

- "You can have a fast answer or my real answer. My real answer arrives tomorrow at nine."
- "Pushing me to answer now will get you my most cautious no. Give me until Monday and you may get a yes."
- "I am not going to commit on the spot — this is exactly the kind of decision that deserves a night."
- "If you need it decided in this meeting, my answer is no. If it can wait until Thursday, it is a genuine maybe."
- "The deadline I can promise is noon tomorrow. I will not miss it."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Vague deferral: 'I will let you know...'
Better: I need to think about it.
Best: I cannot give you the right answer now. I will come back to you by [specific time].
2. Weak: Endless deferral with no committed return
Better: I am still thinking it through.
Best: Specific time commitment made and kept.
3. Weak: Provisional answer presented as final
Better: I think the answer is yes, but I want to check.
Best: Provisionally yes — I will confirm by X.

DECISION TREE

If You are pressed for an answer you cannot give well right now

Decline to answer now. Give a specific time you will return.

"I cannot give you the right answer on the spot. I can have it by [time] — would that work?"

If They need an answer now and cannot wait

Give a provisional answer clearly labelled as provisional.

"If you need something right now: provisionally, yes. I want to confirm that by end of day."

If You have been deferring the same decision for multiple days

Either answer or be honest that you will not change your mind.

"I have been sitting on this — I need to either decide or admit I am avoiding it."

If You defer frequently and people stop trusting the deadlines

Only defer when you will genuinely return. Then return.

SCENARIOS

Salary or scope negotiation: asked for your number on the spot

Defer with a specific return time rather than guessing. — "I need to think about that properly. Can I come back to you by end of week?"

Being asked to commit to something you have not thought through

Name that you need time. Give a specific time. — "I do not want to commit to that without thinking it through. Can I give you an answer by Thursday?"

Emotional conversation where you need time to process

Defer without making it feel like avoidance. — "I want to respond to that properly — not right now. Can we talk tomorrow morning?"

Technical question outside your current knowledge

Defer with a commitment to check. — "I want to verify that rather than guess. I will confirm by end of day."

WORKED EXAMPLE

Without the technique

You: Let me think about it and get back to you.

(A week passes. They follow up. You still have not thought about it.)

(Trust erodes around your reliability)

With the technique

You: I want to give this proper thought — I'll come back to you by Friday with a clear answer.

Other: Perfect — I'll wait to hear from you Friday.

COMMON MISTAKES

The unbounded deferral

Sounds like: 'Let me think about it and I will get back to you.'

Better: 'Let me think about it — I will come back to you by Wednesday morning.'

Missing your own deadline

Sounds like: (Thursday arrives; you say nothing and hope they forgot)

Better: 'I promised you an answer today and I need one more day. Tomorrow, guaranteed.'

Deferring what you already know

Sounds like: 'I need a bit more time on this...' — days after you decided

Better: 'I have thought about it, and the honest answer is no.'

Provisional dressed as final

Sounds like: 'Yes, fine, we can do that.' — before you have checked

Better: 'Provisionally yes — I will confirm once I have checked capacity, by end of day.'

Deferring everything

Sounds like: 'Can I come back to you on that?' — for the fourth time in one meeting

Better: Answer what you can answer now. Defer only what genuinely needs the time.

READING THE ROOM

Signs it is working

- You return with answers on the timelines you commit to.
- People accept the deferral because they trust the deadline.
- Your answer, when it comes, is better than the one you would have given on the spot.
- Deferrals are occasional — not habitual.

Signs to adjust

- You defer so often it looks like avoidance.
- You set deadlines and do not keep them.
- You defer when you already know the answer — because you are uncomfortable saying it.
- The deferral is used to manage the other person rather than to genuinely improve the answer.

WHEN NOT TO USE

- When you know the answer already — deferring when you could decide now signals avoidance.
- When the other person needs an answer urgently and deferment will cause real harm or delay.
- When the pattern of deferring to this person is already eroding their trust in your reliability.

RECOVERY LINES

Best line: 'I gave you an answer on the spot that I should have slept on. Can I revise it?'

- "I owed you an answer yesterday and did not deliver. Here it is now, with my apology."
- "I said 'I'll think about it' and never came back — that was a soft no dressed as thinking. The honest answer is no."
- "I gave you an answer on the spot that I should have slept on. Can I revise it?"
- "I keep pushing this decision back. That tells me I am avoiding it, so let me decide now."
- "Let me replace my vague 'soon' with a real time: Thursday, nine o'clock."
- "I deferred that to buy comfort, not thought — you deserved a straight answer at the time."

TECHNIQUE CHAINS

Negotiation chain

Acknowledge the offer -> decline to decide now -> set the return time -> return on time

Thank you — that is a serious offer and I want to treat it seriously.

I am not going to respond to the number today.

I will come back to you by Friday morning with my answer.

It is Friday: I accept, with one adjustment to the start date.

Pressure chain

Name the pressure -> offer the provisional -> bound the confirmation -> confirm

I can hear this is urgent for you.

My provisional answer is yes — treat it as ninety per cent.

I will make it a firm yes or no by five today.

Confirmed: it is a yes.

RELATED TECHNIQUES

TC020 — Confident Uncertainty

Confident Uncertainty is the delivery — 'I do not know yet' said steadily is what makes a deferral sound like judgement, not evasion.

TC012 — Boundary Without Blame

Boundary Without Blame pairs with this — defer first and you never have to set a boundary, or make a promise, on the spot.

TC031 — Slow Down Under Pressure

Slow Down Under Pressure is the in-the-moment version; Bounded Deferment extends the same slowing from seconds to days.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot the bad on-the-spot answer

Notice one moment today when you gave an answer on the spot that you were not confident in.

Day 2 — Specific time commitment

In one deferral today, give a specific time rather than 'I will let you know.'

Day 3 — Keep the deadline

Set a deferral deadline and return on time.

Day 4 — Provisional vs deferred

Practise the difference between 'I do not know yet' (defer) and 'my best current view is X but I want to confirm it' (provisional).

Day 5 — Acknowledge urgency

When someone needs an answer faster than you can give it, give a provisional answer clearly labelled as provisional.

Day 6 — Own the avoidance

Notice any deferral you are making not to improve the answer but to avoid giving it. Address it.

Day 7 — Calibration

Did you keep your deferral commitments? Were your eventual answers better? Did people trust the deadlines?

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I name a specific return time — not just 'later'?
- Did I keep the commitment I made?
- Was the deferral genuine — not avoidance?
- Did I offer a provisional answer when one was possible?
- Did I avoid deferring habitually on things I already know?
- Did I return with a better answer than I would have given on the spot?
- Did people seem to trust the deferral deadline?